

Pure Craftsmanship

Assouline books are less about reading and more about collecting fine art. This is reflected in the price points, which start at ₹8,000 and scale up to ₹5.5 lakh for rare editions. The crown jewels of the store are thise in the Ultimate Collection. "Each volume is a true objet d'art. Like all our books, the Ultimates are conceived by our in-house creative teams and made in Italy by master artisans using traditional techniques," says Alexandre, adding, "The 1,000 hours begin in our offices, where our editors and designers create each volume, working on the images, texts and layout, before it goes to print. The books are hand-bound, and images are printed on art-quality paper and manually tipped onto the page one by one." What's more, each one is presented in a clamshell case with white gloves, because they are meant to be collected and passed on.

Clearly, Assouline's Delhi flagship is confirmation that in the world of modern luxury, print is far from dead. In fact, it is the ultimate status symbol.

SHELF LIFE
Alexandre Assouline (opposite page); the Delhi showroom (left and right)



Gifting a Lifestyle

With the Diwali and festive gifting seasons colliding, the boutique is already witnessing a shift in how the affluent perceive luxury presents. Instead of predictable choices, buyers are looking for pieces that tell a story. "For ultra-HNI clients, their interest lies in the bigger, statement books," says Mohit Monga, the India retail partner for the brand, adding, "Just recently, a client gifted her husband an Assouline Rolex book for his birthday."